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Hong Kong Protest: Fight for Democracy

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Hong Kong is witnessing a massive civil movement for more than five months. Streets are burning because of mass protests with millions of citizens on the streets against its government asking the resignation of its leader. The protest was triggered when the government introduced an amendment in Extradition Bill.

Governing Structure of Hong Kong

Hong Kong was handed over to mainland China in 1997 when the United Kingdom ended administration for the colony and returned control of Hong Kong to China. But now, Hong Kong is an autonomous territory of China which follows 'one country - two systems', making it a special administrative region. Hong Kong has its legislature but Legislative Council (LegCo.) has more representation of mainland China through indirect interference in the formation of a special 6 members election committee. The electoral system in Hong Kong is therefore unique where people do vote but they only elect less than half of the members of LegCo.

Causes of Protest

Chief Executive or leader-of-territory of Hong Kong continues to be voted by Special Election Committee formulated to have Chinese power in LegCo.. Therefore, the council has more representation of Mainland China than Hong Kong citizens. This half-democracy is the indirect cause of protests. Citizens are asking for full democracy and the resignation of Chief Executive(Leader of Hong Kong). Citizens fear the loss of a high degree of autonomy provided by 'Hong Kong Basic Law' as the government of China over-interfere with Hong Kong domestic affairs.

The direct cause of protest and violence is the amendment in Extradition Bill. Hong Kong laws usually don't extradite its people i.e. Hong Kong do not send back fugitive offenders to the place where they have committed the crime. Therefore, Hong Kong can be considered as a shelter to fugitive criminals. But, the Hong Kong government in February proposed an amendment in Criminal Matters Bill, which led to the current huge mass protest. Amendment Bill, if implemented, would have allowed other countries & mainland China to bring back criminals to the territory where they had committed crime. In legal terms, Hong Kong would have extradited its citizens who are accused of criminal cases.

Demands and Violence

Currently, protests shifted its track to more demands. Violence made its way into this civil crisis. Protestors initially demanded the government to completely withdraw of the extradition bill from the legislative process, and the bill was withdrawn on 23 October. Hong Kong protestors asked the resignation of Chief Executive Carrie Lam and the implementation of genuine Right to Vote(Universal Suffrage) for the Legislative Council election. They also demand to release arrested protestors, accused police of misconduct and demands for an independent commission of inquiry. Mass protest now is converted into rebellious demands & violence for better democracy and the future of Hong Kong.
